5 a day

Eating a good variety of fruit and vegetables is an important element of healthy eating. The World Health Organisation (WHO) advises that we eat a minimum of 400g of fruit and veg every day, equating to five portions. This recommended daily amount is thought to help reduce risk of serious health conditions including stroke, heart disease, obesity and type 2 diabetes.

The 5 a day message looks to encourage people to enjoy a variety of different vegetables and fruits as part of a healthy balanced diet.

3.9.1 Measures to prevent enzymatic browning

There are ways to prevent fruits and vegetable from getting oxidized. Here are a few methods :

- Squeeze lime juice on fruits such as banana, apples, avocado, pears and vegetables like potatoes, sweet potatoes to prevent oxidative browning. The juice of other citrus fruits such as oranges and grape fruits can also be used.
- Soak the cut fruits or vegetables in plain water which helps to slow down the oxidation process.
- Blanching fruits or vegetables also prevents browning.
- Wrapping in a cling wrap tightly is also a good way to prevent browning.
- Most importantly, do not use a rusty knife as the iron in it will increase the rate of browning.

Summary

- Vegetables and fruits are essential for balanced diet and good health.
- They not only add colour and variety to the diet but also provide significant amounts of vitamins, minerals and carbohydrates including roughage (fibre).
- When purchasing, select fresh vegetables and fruits which are firm, crisp, bright in colour with no visible bruises or signs of decay and wilting.
- While cooking vegetables, water-soluble nutrients like thiamine, riboflavin, nicotinic acid, pantothenic acid, pyridoxine, folic acid and vitamin C may be dissolved in the cooking water and the nutrients may be lost. Hence care must be taken to adopt proper cooking techniques to prevent loss of nutrients.
- Vegetables and fruits are appealing because of their bright and variable colours which are due to pigments present in the plastids of plant cells.
- The chief pigments of vegetables and fruits are cholorophyll, anthocyanins, anthoxanthins and carotenoids.
- The cut surface of certain vegetables and fruits turn brown or dark due to enzymatic browning which can be prevented by blanching or by using lemon juice.

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